Philosophical Behaviourism

Hard behaviourism (Hempel), soft behaviourism (Ryle) and the issues each faces

This workbook consolidates what you have covered in the slideshow and handout. Work through it in order, or jump to the part you need. Every task can be done on your own, so if you missed a lesson you can still catch up. Answers to the recall tasks are at the back: try first, then check.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

In this workbook

1. Where am I now? A self-check
2. Key terms
3. Quick recall
4. Argument reconstruction
5. Objections and evaluation
6. Exam practice (3, 5, 12 and 25 marks)
7. Answers

Key Thesis

Hard behaviourism (Hempel): all meaningful psychological statements can be translated, without loss of meaning, into statements that use only the concepts of physics: bodily states and movements.

Soft behaviourism (Ryle): statements about the mind are statements about behavioural **dispositions**: what a person would or might do in certain circumstances. These are expressed in ordinary language and cannot be reduced without loss to physics.

Part 01 Where am I now?

How to use this section

Tick a column for each statement **before** you start, then again **when you finish**. Green = I could explain it to someone else. Amber = I half get it. Red = not yet.

I can…	Start	End
explain the difference between hard and soft behaviourism	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain the verification principle and why it motivated Hempel	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
use Hempel's 'Paul has a toothache' example	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain single-track and multi-track dispositions	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain Super-Spartans and perfect actors	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
explain circularity, multiple realisability and the asymmetry problem	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G
reach and defend a judgement on behaviourism	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G	☐ R ☐ A ☐ G

Part 02 Key terms

Task 1 · Match the term to its definition

Write the letter of the correct definition next to each term.

Term	Letter
Hard behaviourism	
Soft behaviourism	
Verification principle	
Disposition	
Multi-track disposition	
Super-Spartan	
Circularity	
Asymmetry	

	Definition
A	An imagined person who feels pain but has trained themselves never to show any pain-behaviour.
B	I know my own mental states directly, but other people's only by inference from their behaviour.
C	A statement is meaningful only if it is analytic or can in principle be verified by experience.
D	Defining a term using the very concept you are trying to define.
E	A tendency to behave in a certain way in certain circumstances, e.g. salt's solubility.
F	The view that mental statements are about behavioural dispositions, expressed in ordinary language.
G	The view that mental statements can be translated without loss into statements using only the language of physics.
H	A disposition that can show itself in many different behaviours depending on circumstances.

Task 2 · Fill the gaps

Use the word bank. Each word is used once.

Key idea Word bank: test · Super-Spartans · Vienna · verification · actor · multi-track · dispositions · single-track

Hempel was influenced by the _____ Circle and its _____ principle. He argued that 'Paul has a toothache' means a list of _____ sentences describing Paul's behaviour and physical state. Ryle's soft behaviourism analyses mental states as _____. Salt dissolving in water is a _____ disposition; fear of a jackal is _____. Putnam's _____ feel pain without showing it, while a perfect _____ shows pain without feeling it.

Task 3 · In your own words

Explain why soft behaviourists say the mind is not a thing hidden inside us, but a way of describing what we are disposed to do. Use one example of your own.

Part 03 Quick recall

How to use this section

Answer from memory first. Then check your notes, and add anything you missed in a different colour. That second colour shows you exactly what to revise.

1. What does Hempel say all meaningful psychological statements can be translated into?

2. Give two of Hempel's test sentences for 'Paul has a toothache'.

3. How does Hempel respond to the pretender (perfect actor)?

4. State one problem with the verification principle itself.

5. Why can soft behaviourism not translate mental states perfectly into behaviour?

6. Explain the circularity problem in one sentence.

7. What is the asymmetry problem?

8. Why is the hard problem of consciousness a problem for behaviourism?

Part 04 Argument reconstruction

How to use this section

Each argument below has been jumbled. Number the lines into the right order (premises first, conclusion last). Then answer the questions underneath. Being able to set out an argument in standard form is exactly what the 5-mark and 12-mark questions reward.

Hempel's argument for hard behaviourism

Order	Jumbled line
	The meaning of a statement is its method of verification.
	Those test conditions concern bodily behaviour and physical states, describable in the language of physics.
	A psychological statement such as 'Paul has a toothache' is verified only by observable test conditions.
	So the meaning of a psychological statement is given by physical statements.
	Therefore, psychology can be translated into physics without loss of meaning.

→ Which premise depends on logical positivism? What happens to the argument if that theory is false?

→ How does the Super-Spartan threaten the conclusion?

The circularity objection to soft behaviourism

Order	Jumbled line
	A disposition to behave in a certain way depends on what else the person believes and desires.
	Therefore, soft behaviourism cannot eliminate mental terms from its analysis of the mind.
	So to analyse one mental state as a disposition, we must mention other mental states.
	An analysis that uses the concept it is analysing is circular.

→ How might Ryle reply (see your handout: open definitions; all definitions are circular in some sense)?

→ Does the reply save behaviourism, or just admit the mind cannot be defined? Explain.

Part 05 Objections and evaluation

How to use this section

For each objection: explain the problem in your own words, write the best response, then judge whether the response works. The hint column is there if you are stuck; cover it up if you want a harder challenge.

Objection	Hint	The problem, in my own words	Best response	Does it work? Why?
Verification principle fails its own test	Is 'only verifiable statements are meaningful' itself verifiable?			
Super-Spartans (Putnam)	Pain with no pain-behaviour at all.			
Perfect actors	Pain-behaviour with no pain.			
Multiple realisability	One mental state → many behaviours; one behaviour → many mental states.			

Objection	Hint	The problem, in my own words	Best response	Does it work? Why?
Circularity	Defining belief requires mentioning other beliefs.			
Asymmetry of self-knowledge	I don't observe my own behaviour to know I'm in pain.			
Dualist arguments (spec)	Conceivability: a being behaviourally identical to me with no mind.			
Hard problem / qualia	What is it like to be in pain? (Nagel)			

Ranking the objections

Which objection is the **most** damaging, and which is the **least**? Justify your choice: a strong objection attacks a key premise and is hard to answer.

Most damaging: _____ because...

Least damaging: _____ because...

Building a judgement

Is philosophical behaviourism a convincing account of the mind? Decide whether soft behaviourism survives the objections that defeat hard behaviourism.

Key idea Sentence starters: *The strongest argument for this view is... because...* · *However, this is undermined by...* · *A defender might reply that... but this fails / succeeds because...* · *Therefore, on balance...*

Part 06 Exam practice

How to use this section

On Paper 2 the **3-, 5- and 12-mark** questions test **AO1** only: knowledge and understanding, shown through precise, accurate explanation. The **25-mark** question is **5 marks AO1 + 20 marks AO2**: you must argue, evaluate and reach a judgement that your essay supports throughout.

Spend roughly a minute per mark. Plan before you write.

3 marks · What is meant by 'hard behaviourism'?

Key idea AO1 · A precise definition or short point. One or two accurate sentences; no evaluation needed.

5 marks · Explain the difference between hard and soft behaviourism.

Key idea AO1 · Set out the idea or argument clearly and in logical order. Precise terminology; a standard-form layout often works best.

Planning frame

1. Define hard behaviourism (Hempel): translation into physics.
2. Define soft behaviourism (Ryle): dispositions in ordinary language.
3. Key difference 1: reducibility to physics.

4. Key difference 2: role of logical positivism / verification.

12 marks · Explain how the possibility of Super-Spartans and perfect actors challenges philosophical behaviourism.

Key idea AO1 · A full, precise explanation. Show how the ideas connect logically, step by step. Do **not** evaluate: explain.

Planning frame

1. Set out what behaviourism claims (mental state = behaviour/disposition).
2. Explain Super-Spartans: mental state without behaviour.
3. Explain perfect actors: behaviour without mental state.
4. Show how each separates mind from behaviour, so the two cannot be identical, and Hempel's attempted reply.

25 marks · Is philosophical behaviourism true?

Key idea AO1 (5) + AO2 (20) · State your line of argument in the introduction and keep to it. Every paragraph should argue, not just describe: point → objection → response → mini-judgement. End with a conclusion that follows from what you have argued.

Model structure

Section	What to do	My plan
Introduction	Define the key terms. State your thesis: the answer you will defend.	
Paragraph 1	Hard behaviourism and the verification principle → the principle fails its own test → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 2	Super-Spartans and perfect actors → behaviourist replies → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 3	Soft behaviourism's dispositions → circularity and multiple realisability → mini-judgement.	
Paragraph 4	The asymmetry problem and qualia → replies → mini-judgement.	
Conclusion	Restate your judgement and explain **why** the balance of argument supports it. No new arguments.	

Write your essay on lined paper, or continue below.

Reflect

Go back to Part 01 and fill in the **End** column. Which statement is still red or amber? Write one specific thing you will do about it.

Part 07 Answers

How to use this section

Use these to check Parts 02–04. Exam answers are not given here: bring them to your teacher, or mark against the AO guidance.

Task 1 · Matching

Hard behaviourism = G · Soft behaviourism = F · Verification principle = C · Disposition = E · Multi-track disposition = H · Super-Spartan = A · Circularity = D · Asymmetry = B

Task 2 · Gaps

(1) Vienna · (2) verification · (3) test · (4) dispositions · (5) single-track · (6) multi-track · (7) Super-Spartans · (8) actor

Quick recall

1. Statements using only the concepts of physics (bodily states and movements), with no psychological concepts.
2. E.g. Paul weeps and makes gestures; he says 'I have a toothache'; a decayed tooth is found; his blood pressure changes; processes occur in his central nervous system.
3. Only some of the test sentences would be true; a fuller examination, including of the central nervous system, would show he is faking.
4. It cannot itself be verified (it fails its own test); 'in principle' is unclear; it makes much ordinary knowledge meaningless.
5. There is no perfect fit between beliefs and actions: dispositions are multi-track and depend on other beliefs and circumstances.
6. To say how a belief shows itself in behaviour, we must mention other beliefs and desires, so mental terms reappear in the definition.
7. I know my own mental states immediately, without observing my behaviour, but know others' only by inference; behaviourism makes both the same.
8. Behaviour is third-person; it leaves out what it is like (Nagel) to have a mental state: qualia.

Arguments in order

Hempel's argument for hard behaviourism

1. The meaning of a statement is its method of verification.
2. A psychological statement such as 'Paul has a toothache' is verified only by observable test conditions.
3. Those test conditions concern bodily behaviour and physical states, describable in the language of physics.
4. So the meaning of a psychological statement is given by physical statements.
5. Therefore, psychology can be translated into physics without loss of meaning.

The circularity objection to soft behaviourism

1. A disposition to behave in a certain way depends on what else the person believes and desires.
2. So to analyse one mental state as a disposition, we must mention other mental states.
3. An analysis that uses the concept it is analysing is circular.
4. Therefore, soft behaviourism cannot eliminate mental terms from its analysis of the mind.

Objections: model responses

Objection	Possible response
Verification principle fails its own test	Hempel could treat it as a recommendation rather than a claim; but then hard behaviourism loses its foundation.
Super-Spartans (Putnam)	Hempel: they are not in pain if the symptoms are absent, or CNS tests would reveal it; but this looks like denying the obvious.
Perfect actors	Hempel: only some test sentences would be true; deeper physical examination would expose the pretence.
Multiple realisability	Soft behaviourist: dispositions are multi-track and open-ended, not fixed lists.
Circularity	Ryle: definitions can be open; arguably all definitions are circular in some sense.
Asymmetry of self-knowledge	Ryle: we learn about ourselves in much the same way as others; but immediate first-person access is hard to deny.
Dualist arguments (spec)	If behaviour is what mind *means*, such a being is not genuinely conceivable; but zombie intuitions remain.
Hard problem / qualia	A behaviourist may say 'what it is like' talk is itself confused; most find this unconvincing.